
ARE LOS ANGELES AIRBNB LISTINGS CASUAL OR COMMERCIAL?

A PREPRINT

June 3, 2026

Abstract

This report uses Los Angeles Airbnb listings from Inside Airbnb to explore whether listings look more like casual home sharing or commercial short-term rentals.

Weiyu Zhang
UCLA

1 Introduction

The main research question is: **Are Los Angeles Airbnb listings mainly casual home sharing, or do they look more like commercial short-term rentals?** To answer the question, I analyze room type, neighborhood concentration, yearly availability, minimum nights, review activity, and host listing counts.

Not all Airbnb listings are used in the same way. Some listings may be occasional rentals, such as a private room or a home available only certain times of the year. Other listings look more commercial, such as entire homes that are available for many days of the year or hosts with multiple listings. The goal is to describe patterns in the dataset.

2 Data Source

The dataset used is the Los Angeles Airbnb `listings.csv` file from Inside Airbnb.

3 Variable Overview

Table 1: Variable descriptions for the Los Angeles Airbnb listings dataset.

Variable	Description
id	Unique ID number for each Airbnb listing
name	Name or title of the Airbnb listing
host id	Unique ID number for the host
host profile id	Host profile ID included in the source dataset
host name	Name of the host
neighbourhood group	Larger neighborhood group, if available
neighbourhood	Neighborhood where the listing is located
latitude	Latitude coordinate of the listing
longitude	Longitude coordinate of the listing
room type	Type of Airbnb space, such as entire home, private room, or shared room
price	Nightly listing price, but this column is missing in the recent file used

Variable	Description
minimum nights	Minimum number of nights required for a booking
number of reviews	Total number of reviews for the listing
last review	Date of the most recent review
reviews per month	Average number of reviews per month
calculated host listings count	Number of listings connected to the same host
availability 365	Number of days the listing is available in the next 365 days
number of reviews ltm	Number of reviews in the last twelve months
license	License or registration information

Table 1 explains the main variables in the dataset.

4 Summary Statistics

Table 2: Summary statistics for cleaned Los Angeles Airbnb listings.

Statistic	Value
Number of listings	45585.00
Number of neighborhoods	266.00
Median minimum nights	30.00
Mean minimum nights	19.23
Median number of reviews	6.00
Mean number of reviews	39.18
Median availability	254.00
Mean availability	214.08
Median host listings	2.00
Mean host listings	20.42

Table 2 gives a quick overview of the cleaned dataset. The dataset includes 45,585 listings across 266 neighborhoods, so it is large enough to show significant patterns. The median minimum stay is 30 nights, which suggests that many listings are not just for very short weekend trips. The median availability is also high, at 254 days, meaning many listings are available for a great part of the year.

5 Room Type Distribution

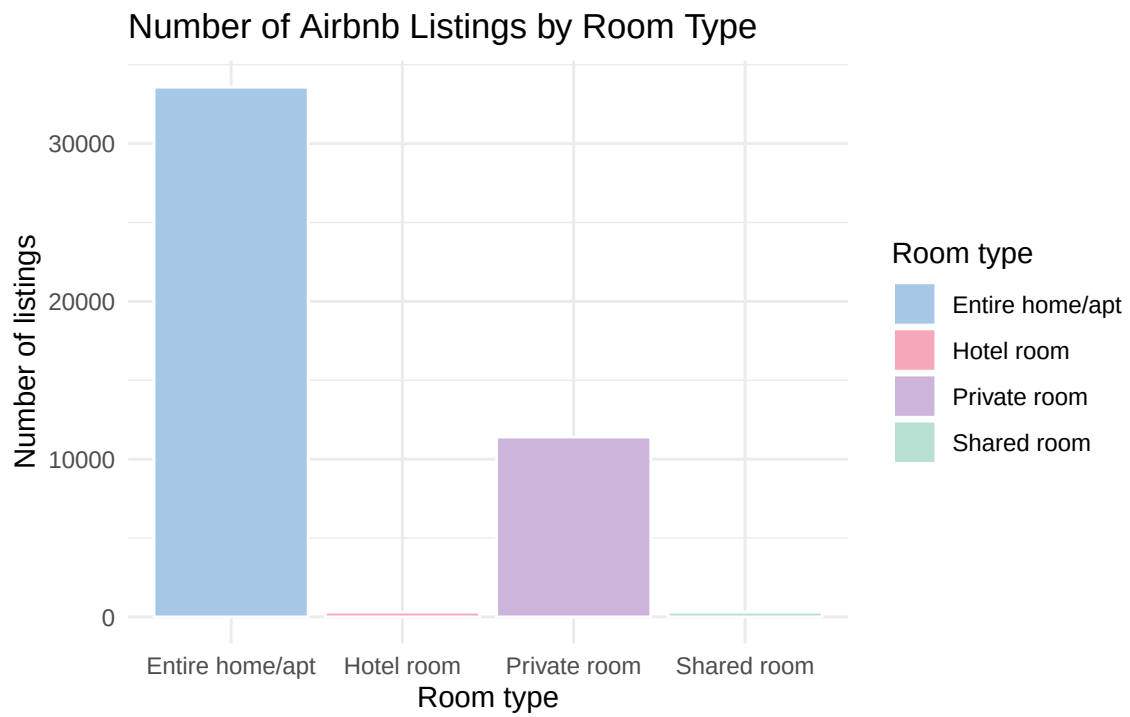


Figure 1 shows how Airbnb listings are divided by room type. Entire homes or apartments make up the largest group of listings, with over 30,000 listings. While private rooms are the second largest group. This shows that many Los Angeles Airbnb listings may not simply be extra rooms in someone's home.

6 Availability by Room Type

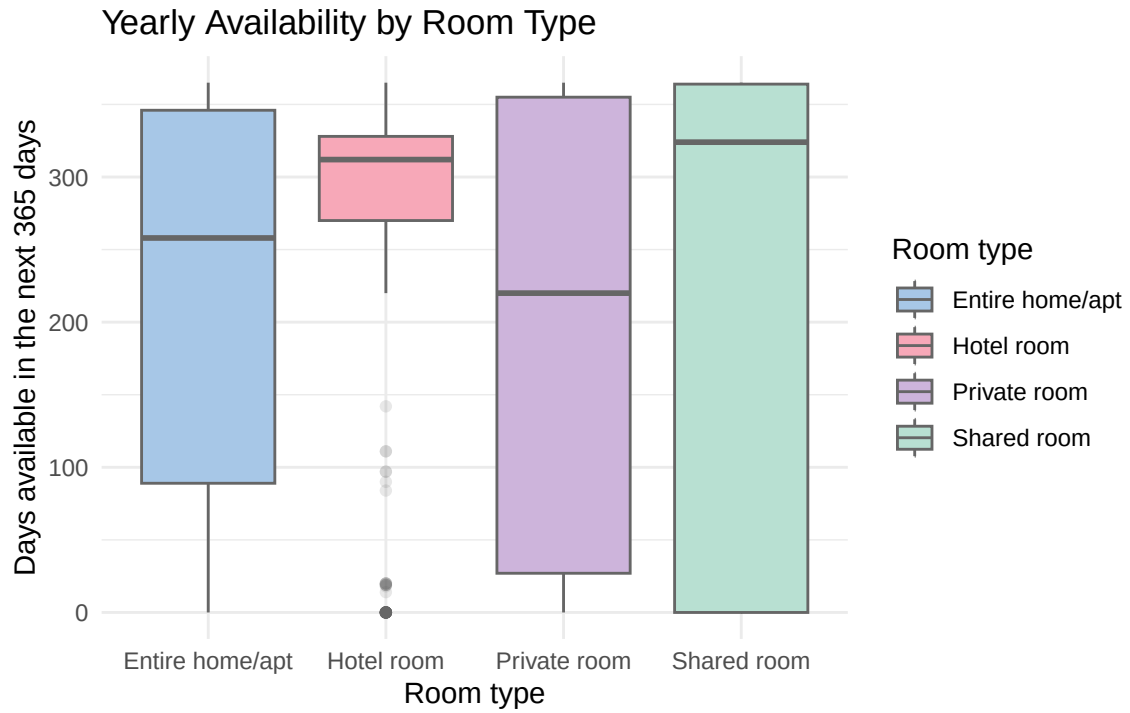


Figure 2 compares yearly availability across room types. The boxplots show that many listings are available for a large number of days in the year, especially hotel rooms and shared rooms. Entire homes and private rooms have more variation, which means some are only available part of the year while others are available almost year round.

7 Top Neighborhoods by Listing Count

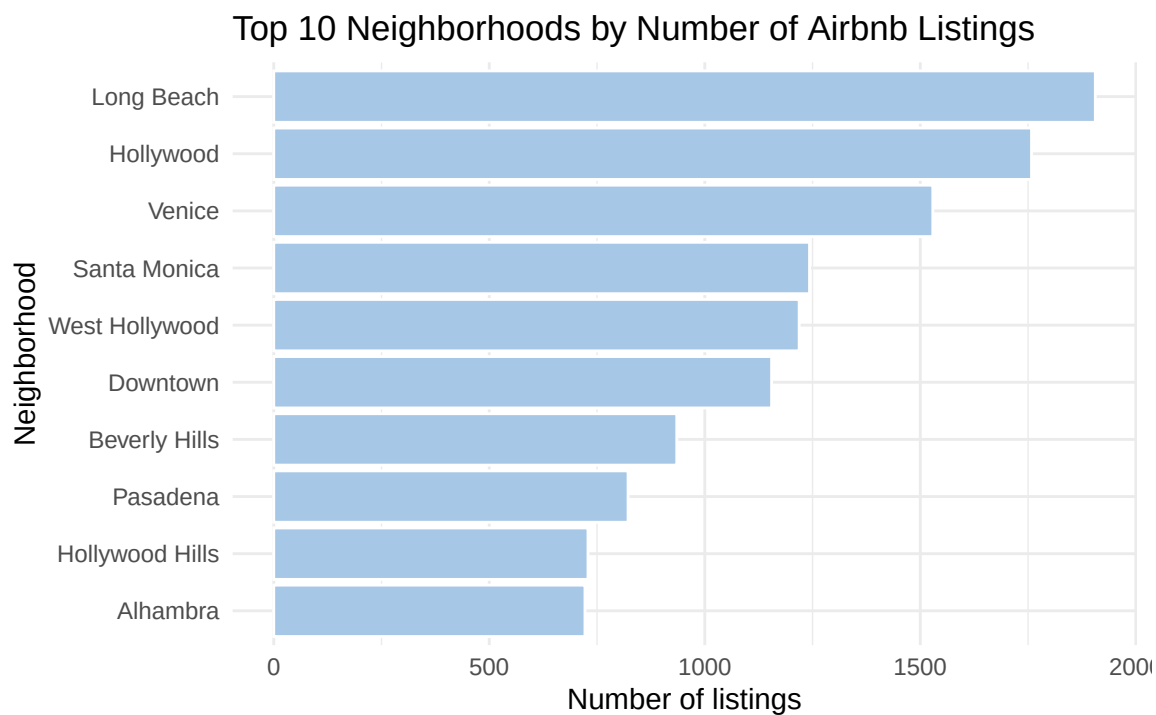


Figure 3 shows that Airbnb listings are not evenly spread across Los Angeles. Long Beach, Hollywood, Venice, Santa Monica, and West Hollywood are among the neighborhoods with the most listings. This shows that Airbnb activity is concentrated in specific areas rather than evenly distributed across the city.

8 Host Listing Counts

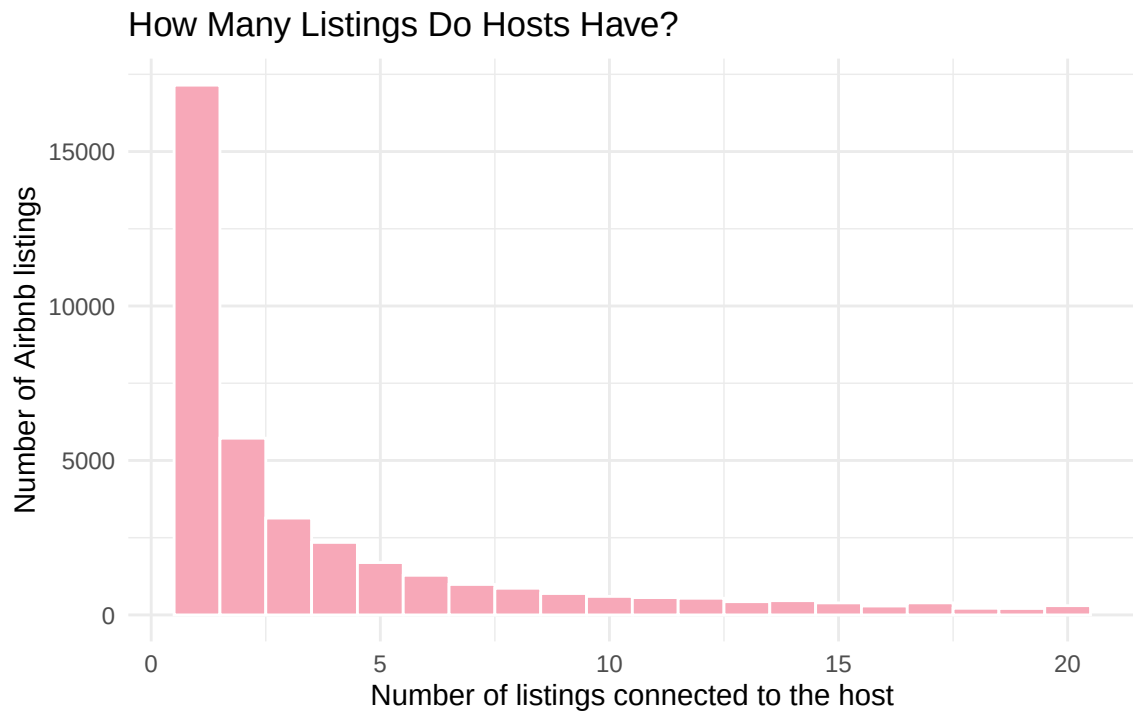


Figure 4 shows that many listings are connected to hosts with only a small number of listings, but there are also many listings connected to hosts with multiple listings. This matters because hosts with several listings may look more like professional or commercial hosts than casual hosts renting out one space.

9 Commercial Style Signal

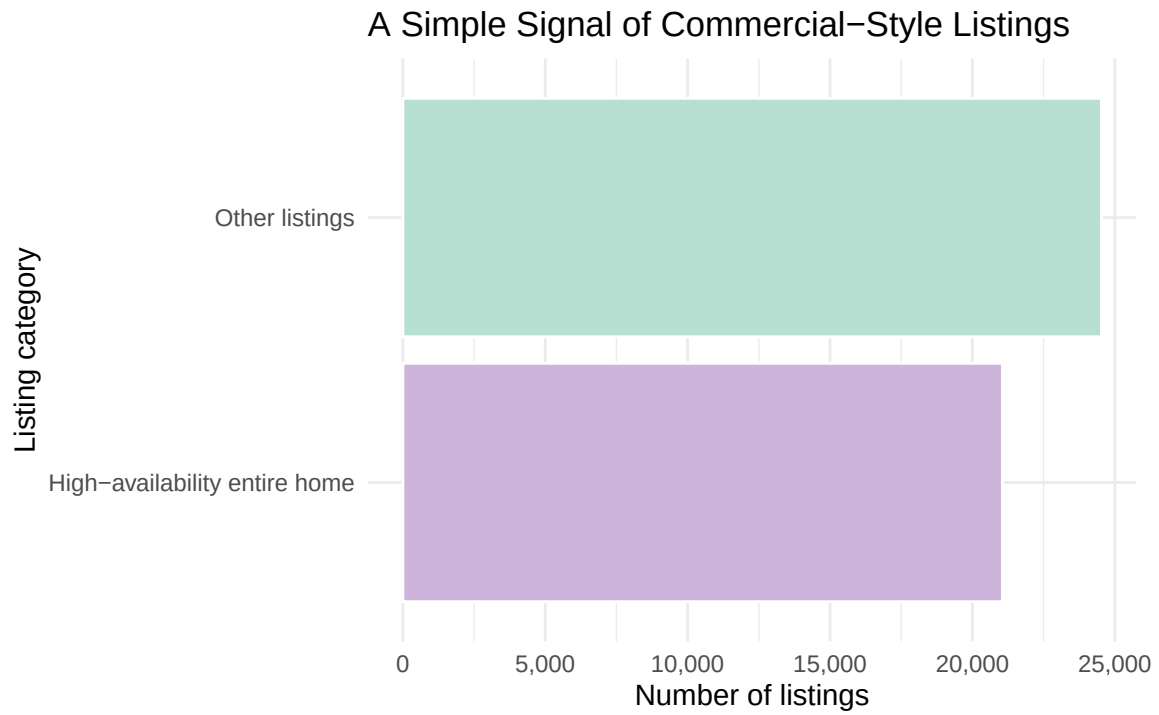


Figure 5 compares high availability entire homes with all other listings. There are more than 20,000 listings that are entire homes or apartments and available at least 180 days per year. This does not prove that these listings are commercial, but it gives a sign that many listings may look less like occasional home sharing.

10 Reviews and Availability

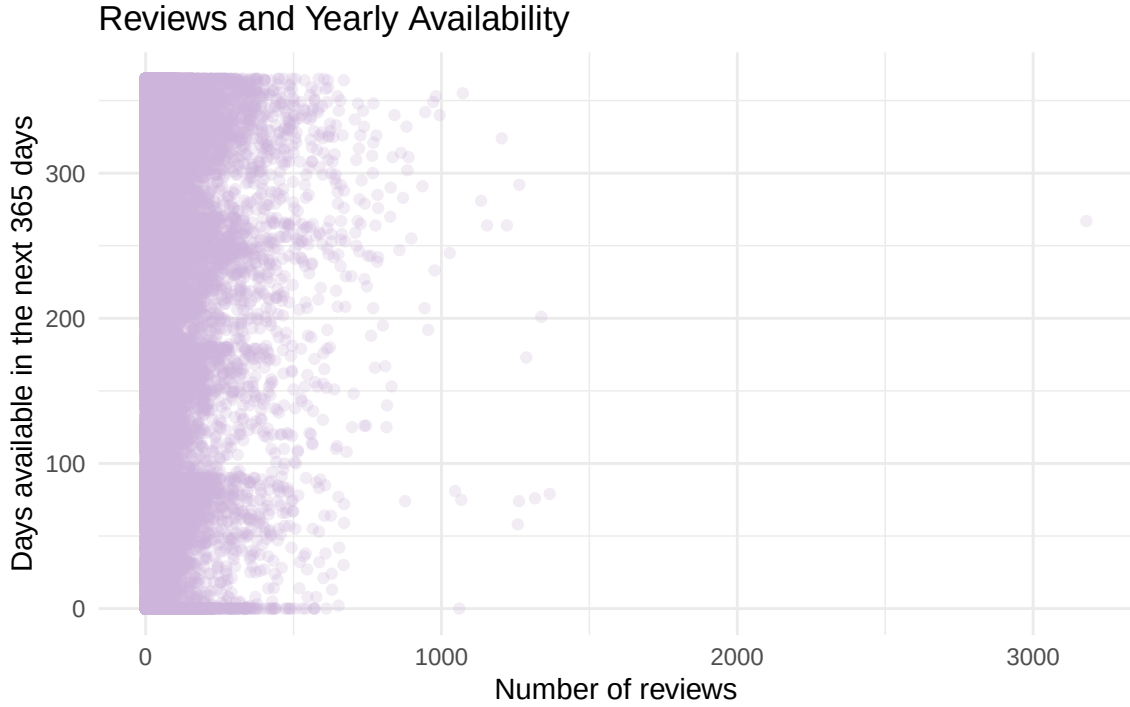


Figure 6 compares the number of reviews with yearly availability. Most listings have lower review counts, but a few listings have very high numbers of reviews. There is not a clear pattern where more reviews always means more availability, but the graph still shows that listing activity varies a lot across the dataset.

11 Conclusion

This exploratory data analysis found several patterns in Los Angeles Airbnb listings. First, room type is an important part of the dataset because listings are divided into categories including entire homes, private rooms, and shared spaces. Second, availability differs across listings, and listings available for most of the year look less like occasional home sharing. Third, listings are not evenly spread across Los Angeles neighborhoods because some neighborhoods have much higher listing counts than others. Also, hosts with multiple listings appear more commercial than hosts with only one listing.

Overall, the data shows that Los Angeles Airbnb listings are not all the same. Some listings look like casual home sharing, while others have patterns that look more like commercial short-term rentals.

12 References

Inside Airbnb. "Get the Data: Los Angeles, California, United States." Inside Airbnb. Dataset file used: `listings.csv`.

Inside Airbnb. "Data Dictionary." Inside Airbnb.